

Seizure first aid

Many seizures end by themselves. Your job is to protect the person, prevent injury, and gently care for them afterwards — and to recognise situations that do need urgent medical help.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES NOW IF...

When a seizure is an emergency

- The seizure (shaking/convulsing) lasts **longer than 5 minutes**.
- Another seizure starts soon after the first, or they do not regain awareness between seizures.
- The person is **hurt, has trouble breathing, or does not wake up** after the shaking stops.
- The seizure happens **in water**.
- It is the person's **first-ever seizure**, or you do not know their history.
- The person is **pregnant**, has **diabetes**, or another serious health condition.

Call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK). When in doubt, call.

What to do during a convulsive seizure

- 1 **Stay calm and stay with them.** Note the time the seizure starts so you know how long it lasts.
- 2 **Protect them from injury.** Move away hard or sharp objects. Cushion the head with something soft (a folded jacket). Take off glasses and loosen anything tight around the neck.
- 3 **Do not restrain them and do not put anything in their mouth.** Let the movements happen. Holding them down or putting objects (or your fingers) in the mouth can injure them or you — and you cannot stop the seizure that way.
- 4 **When the shaking stops, roll them onto their side** (recovery position). This keeps the airway clear and lets saliva drain. Check they are breathing.
- 5 **Stay until they are fully alert.** Reassure them calmly — they may be confused, sleepy, or upset for a while. Do not give food, drink, or medicine until they are fully awake and able to swallow.

COMMON MYTHS — DO NOT DO THESE

- **Never put anything in the mouth** — a spoon, wallet, fingers, or food. A person **cannot swallow their tongue**. Objects can break teeth, block the airway, or be bitten.
- **Do not hold the person down** or try to stop their movements.
- **Do not try to "wake" them** by slapping, shouting, or throwing water.
- Do not give anything to eat or drink until they are fully recovered.

Not all seizures involve shaking

Some seizures cause staring, confusion, repeated movements (like lip-smacking or fumbling), wandering, or simply being unaware for a short time. The person may not respond normally. **Do not grab or restrain them.** Gently guide them away from danger (roads, stairs, water), speak calmly and quietly, stay with them, and wait for them to come round. They may not remember it afterwards.

Fever-related seizures in young children

OFTEN BRIEF, BUT WATCH CLOSELY

Young children sometimes have a seizure when they have a high fever (a "febrile seizure"). It is frightening to watch; many are brief, but the child still needs careful watching. Give the same first aid: keep them safe, do not restrain or put anything in the mouth, and lay them on their side. Call for emergency help if it lasts more than 5 minutes, if it is their first one, if they have trouble breathing, or if the child seems very unwell or does not recover quickly.

After the seizure

- Stay calm and kind. Tiredness, confusion, headache, or embarrassment afterwards are normal.
- Give them space and privacy — don't crowd them.
- Note what you saw to tell them or the medical team: how long it lasted, what the body did, and any injury. This information is genuinely helpful.
- If they have a seizure-action plan or rescue medicine and a trained person is present, follow it.

Sources

- CDC — About epilepsy (background on seizures and epilepsy).
- Epilepsy Foundation — Seizure first aid and safety (stay, safe, side; do not restrain or put anything in the mouth).
- World Health Organization — Epilepsy fact sheet (global burden; first aid; do not restrain or place objects in the mouth).
- NHS — Epilepsy and what to do when someone has a seizure.
- American Red Cross — first-aid training and resources.

Guidance reflects widely taught seizure first aid for lay responders. Details vary between training bodies and regions — follow your local first-aid training and emergency services.

This guide is general information, not medical advice. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.